

Voter Resentment and the Strategic Dynamics of Enfranchisement

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Abstract

Why do parties resist enfranchising new voter groups? Parties that obstruct enfranchisement often accumulate negative sentiment among the affected group, and this resentment manifests as an electoral penalty for the obstructing party if enfranchisement eventually occurs. We formalize the concept of voter resentment, and we develop a dynamic formal model to analyze when and why parties resist enfranchising new voter groups. We show that resisting enfranchisement can offer short-term protection against electoral loss, but it risks the party's long-run electoral viability. Three key findings inform how parties navigate this dilemma. (1) Increased voter sensitivity to past disenfranchisement generally incentivizes incumbent parties to enfranchise sooner. However, (2) this effect is moderated by the party's existing partisan advantage. Parties with a strong initial partisan base may become less likely to enfranchise as voter sensitivity to past obstruction rises, opting to rely on their core supporters rather than appeal to a resentful new group. (3) The precision of information regarding the new group's latent support also interacts with partisan strength; higher precision can encourage enfranchisement for electorally strong parties but deter it for weaker ones. The results offer implications for voting rights activists, whose pro-democracy movements may increase voters' sensitivity to disenfranchisement.

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1 Introduction

While many countries have had competitive elections for centuries, universal suffrage is a more recent phenomenon. This apparent paradox is due to the fact that countries rarely enfranchise all adult citizens upon initial democratization. Instead, they extend the franchise to select groups at later dates. This was, for instance, the modal path for women’s enfranchisement: of the countries where women are enfranchised today, in only 14% were women enfranchised alongside men (Teele, 2018a, 2). And for some countries, the path to universal suffrage is an iterative process of partial franchise extensions. The United Kingdom needed five different reforms to reach full enfranchisement (Freeman and Snidai, 1982). As a result, many franchise extensions have occurred in established electoral settings.

It is not surprising, then, that political parties will seek to leverage enfranchisement opportunities for political gain. Parties can pursue new supporters among the unenfranchised (Llavador and Oxoby, 2005), positioning themselves as a champion of that group. Other parties might take the opposite stance, anticipating that the new voters would support their opponents. Such was the case with the United States’s enfranchisement of poor White men, recent immigrants, and Black Americans, wherein political parties established clear positions on suffrage (Keyssar, 2000).

Yet, opposing enfranchisement is not a strategy without risk. Voters often choose parties which enact favorable policies and oppose those which do not advance their interests (Healy and Malhotra, 2013). Scholars have long established that voters select candidates based on economic conditions and social policies (Key, 1966; Fiorina, 1978; Kiewiet and Rivers, 1984; Berry and Howell, 2007; Karol and Miguel, 2007; Malhotra and Kuo, 2008; Gasper and Reeves, 2011; Margalit, 2011; Bechtel and Hainmueller, 2011). We contend that individuals may also vote retrospectively on suffrage policies. In particular, disenfranchised citizens may resent the party that opposes their suffrage, making them disinclined to vote for that party if they were to be enfranchised.

Under what conditions do parties forestall enfranchisement today, risking resentful voters in the future? To answer this question, we solve a dynamic formal model in which the incumbent chooses to forestall enfranchisement or not, and in so doing generates an observable record of the party’s obstruction. The key parameter in the model is the salience of obstruction to voters; the sensitivity parameter, as we term it, captures how strongly prospective voters condition future support on past obstruction. This sensitivity is exogenous to the model and may plausibly result from, among other things, social movements or campaigns that elevate voting rights relative to other political issues.

Our analysis produces two key findings. First, as a new voter group becomes more sen-

sitive to its past exclusion, incumbent parties are generally more incentivized to enfranchise them sooner to avoid future electoral punishment. We call this the *preemption effect*. Second, the party’s existing electoral strength moderates this effect. A party with a strong, loyal base of core voters may react to increased sensitivity in the opposite way, opting to forgo the resentful new group and entrench its position by relying solely on its traditional supporters. We call this the *entrenchment effect*.

The baseline model assumes that parties have perfect information about the current partisan alignment of potential voters. However, parties often confront uncertainty about the partisan allegiance of the individuals they seek to enfranchise. We therefore relax the assumption of perfect information and model the precision of parties’ information about potential voters. We find that the precision of information about the new group’s latent preferences interacts with partisan strength; better information can encourage a strong party to enfranchise while deterring a weak one.

Taken together, the results carry important implications for both historical analysis and pro-democracy activism. Contextualizing the results within the Civil Rights Movement and the subsequent passage of the Voting Rights Act, the model provides a theoretical basis for most Southern Democrats’ stalwart opposition to Black voting rights, as well as for urban Southerners’ limited support for voting rights. The results are also relevant for voting rights activists today. They suggest that, while raising the salience of disenfranchisement can pressure competitive parties to reform, such activism may backfire with electorally secure incumbents. We return to these discussions in section 6.

Our model makes a key theoretical contribution by introducing a novel dynamic of path-dependent voter allegiance – voter resentment – into the study of franchise extension. By examining how a party’s historical stance on suffrage endogenously shapes partisan preferences, our approach moves beyond existing theoretical frameworks and takes seriously the partisan political dynamics in which most modern enfranchisements have occurred. To situate our contribution, we now turn to the literature from which our model builds and departs.

2 Existing Literature on Strategic Enfranchisement

Our model contributes to a rich literature in political economy on the strategic logic of franchise extension. According to this scholarship, elites extend the franchise as a way to solve (i) external conflict, meaning conflict from below or (ii) internal conflict, meaning

among elites (Freeman and Snidai, 1982; Jack and Lagunoff, 2006; Aidt and Franck, 2025).¹

The literature has identified several types of external conflict that might drive elites to enfranchise: uprisings (Ellis and Fender, 2011; Aidt and Jensen, 2014), non-violent social movements (Banaszak, 1996; McCammon and Campbell, 2001; Tilly, 2004; Teele, 2014), and conscription demands (Janowitz, 1976; Keyssar, 2000; Ticchi and Vindigni, 2008).²

Acemoglu and Robinson (2000) canonized the uprising mechanism and reinvigorated the study of strategic democratization. In their seminal model, a unified elite faces the disenfranchised masses, and elites extend the right to vote as a credible commitment to future redistribution, thereby staving off the threat of revolution. While this framework provides a powerful explanation for major democratic transitions, its focus on class conflict between a unified elite and the masses abstracts from the intra-elite competition that often drives institutional change.

Other work highlights internal conflict as a central mechanism, arguing that, not only are there economic cleavages among elites, but that these cleavages themselves can be a catalyst for enfranchisement.³ Lizzeri and Persico (2004) argues that when the elites who prefer public goods outnumber those who prefer particularistic transfers, franchise extensions follow. Llavador and Oxoby (2005) adds that, in the presence of such cleavages, political parties can “look to disenfranchised groups for ... political support.” We share Llavador and Oxoby’s perspective and contend that partisan competition is central to many franchise extensions.

Indeed, scholars have established that high levels of party competition can encourage parties to seek additional supporters among disenfranchised adults. For instance, Teele (2018b) documents that U.S. state legislatures were more likely to support women’s suffrage under conditions of high partisan competition. Conversely, the absence of competition can forestall enfranchisement entirely; Schattschneider (1942) observes that the U.S. region that most severely restricted the franchise – the post-Reconstruction South – was also defined by the monopolistic control of the Democratic Party. Comparable dynamics appear beyond the United States. Parties from Chile to Finland have supported franchise extensions in order to gain an advantage in challenging political environments (Collier, 1999; Llavador and Oxoby, 2005).⁴ However, while this literature empirically documents when parties seek new voters,

¹The schema is not mutually exclusive. External conflict, particularly in the form of social movements, can affect how politicians perceive the consequences of franchise extension for intra-elite political competition (Teale, 2018a).

²See Cox, Dincecco and Onorato (2023) for related work on the effect of war on the emergence of parliamentary governance.

³This line of argumentation differs from classic accounts, e.g., Engerman and Sokoloff (2005), that posit enfranchisement is more likely under homogeneous preferences.

⁴Strategic considerations also shape current voters’ preferences over inclusion, with partisan support for

it generally treats partisan support as exogenously fixed. We advance this framework by endogenizing voter preferences to the history of suffrage itself.

A key challenge for politicians seeking to gain more voters through the franchise is discerning potential voters’ political preferences. Elites may rely on group heuristics (Barnes, 2020), economic cleavages (Llavador and Oxoby, 2005; Ansell and Samuels, 2014), or religious identification (Przeworski, 2009) to deduce potential voters’ allegiance. These cues, of course, are imperfect predictors of long-run partisanship.⁵ Yet, no theoretical treatment of strategic enfranchisement has modeled uncertainty about future voters’ preferences; we attempt to fill this gap.

Our model synthesizes the insights of this vast literature while introducing a novel mechanism in voter resentment. By formalizing voter resentment, we illustrate how past decisions to disenfranchise can constrain future enfranchisement opportunities and affect voter allegiances. We now introduce the baseline model.

3 Model

We analyze a two-period game, $t \in \{1, 2\}$, between two political parties, A and B. In each period t , one party is the incumbent, denoted $I_t \in \{A, B\}$. The incumbent controls the decision on enfranchisement of a specific group of voters. Without loss of generality, assume Party A is the incumbent in the first period ($I_1 = A$).

The electorate consists of two groups: core voters, constituting a measure $1 - \lambda$ of the total, and potential voters, constituting a measure λ , where $\lambda \in [0, 1]$. The allegiance of core voters is fixed: a share γ of them supports Party A, and the complementary share $1 - \gamma$ supports Party B. The parameter γ thus quantifies Party A’s established partisan strength among core voters. Potential voters, if enfranchised, cast their vote based on a latent signal $\theta_t \in [0, 1]$, drawn i.i.d. from a uniform distribution $U[0, 1]$ in each period t . A higher θ_t indicates stronger support for Party A among potential voters. Both parties observe θ_t at the start of each period t .

The state variable $E_t \in \{0, 1\}$ tracks the enfranchisement of potential voters, where $E_t = 1$ if they have been enfranchised in any period $k < t$, and $E_t = 0$ otherwise. At the beginning of the game, potential voters are disenfranchised ($E_1 = 0$). If potential voters are not yet enfranchised at the start of period t ($E_t = 0$), the incumbent party I_t decides whether or not to enfranchise them, $e_t \in \{0, 1\}$, where $e_t = 1$ represents enfranchisement

enfranchisement responding to perceived electoral implications (Alarian and Zonszein, 2025).

⁵For the limitations of the “woman voter” heuristic in the U.S., see McConaughy (2013); Wolbrecht and Corder (2020).

and $e_t = 0$ represents non-enfranchisement. Once enfranchised, voters remain enfranchised in all subsequent periods. Formally, $E_{t+1} = \max(E_t, e_t)$ for $t = 0$, with $E_0 = 0$. If all voters are enfranchised in period t ($E_t = 1$), the game ends.

A core feature of our model is the development of resentment among potential voters toward parties that have historically chosen to block their enfranchisement. We model this resentment as a state variable that evolves as a function of parties' enfranchisement actions. We denote this state variable r_t^i , where $i \in \{A, B\}$ denotes the party against whom period t resentment is targeted. Let n_t^i denote the cumulative number of periods up to the start of period t in which party $i \in \{A, B\}$ was the incumbent ($I_k = i$) and chose not to enfranchise the potential voters ($E_k = 0$ and $e_k = 0$). That is, for $i \in \{A, B\}$,

$$n_t^i = \sum_{k=1}^{t-1} \mathbb{I}_{I_k=i \wedge E_k=0 \wedge e_k=0}$$

with $n_1^A = n_1^B = 0$. The resentment of potential voters toward party i at the start of period t , denoted r_t^i , is the share of all historical disenfranchisement actions by party i :

$$r_t^A := \begin{cases} \frac{n_t^A}{n_t^A + n_t^B} & \text{if } n_t^A + n_t^B > 0 \\ 0 & \text{if } n_t^A + n_t^B = 0 \end{cases}$$

$$r_t^B := \begin{cases} \frac{n_t^B}{n_t^A + n_t^B} & \text{if } n_t^A + n_t^B > 0 \\ 0 & \text{if } n_t^A + n_t^B = 0 \end{cases}$$

According to this definition, potential voters do not have resentment toward either party at the beginning of the game. If only one party i has disenfranchised in a previous time period, then $r_t^i = 1$ and $r_t^{-i} = 0$. If one or both parties have disenfranchised in the past, then $n_t^A + n_t^B > 0$ and $r_t^A + r_t^B = 1$, and potential voters' resentment toward party i is equal to party i 's share of the total disenfranchisement history.

3.1 Voting and Election Outcome

At the end of each period t , an election takes place. The voting behavior of core voters is exogenously fixed, and potential voters participate if and only if they are enfranchised (i.e., $e_t = 1$ or $E_t = 1$).

Should potential voters be enfranchised, the share of them supporting Party A, denoted $s_t^A \in [0, 1]$, is a convex combination of their intrinsic preference and resentment-adjusted preference. This support s_t^A is a function of three factors: the realization of a latent signal

$\theta_t \sim U[0, 1]$, current resentment levels r_t^A and r_t^B towards Party A and Party B respectively, and a parameter $\alpha \in [0, 1]$ capturing the sensitivity of potential voters to past disenfranchisement actions. The sensitivity parameter α quantifies the weight potential voters assign to historical disenfranchisement conduct, relative to their current intrinsic preference θ_t . If $\alpha = 0$, past conduct is irrelevant, and $s_t^A = \theta_t$. As α increases, voters place greater weight on the resentment component. A higher accumulated resentment r_t^A , ceteris paribus, reduces the share of potential voters supporting Party A.

The share of enfranchised potential voters supporting Party A, s_t^A , is given by

$$s_t^A = (1 - \alpha) \cdot \theta_t + \alpha \cdot (\theta_t \cdot (1 - r_t^A) + (1 - \theta_t) \cdot r_t^B).$$

Analogously, s_t^B , is

$$s_t^B = (1 - \alpha) \cdot (1 - \theta_t) + \alpha \cdot (\theta_t \cdot r_t^A + (1 - \theta_t) \cdot (1 - r_t^B)).$$

It follows that $s_t^A + s_t^B = 1$. The entirety of the enfranchised potential voter group is allocated between the two parties. Given Party A is the incumbent in the first period, $r_2^A = 0$ if A enfranchises potential voters, and $r_2^A = 1$ if it does not. In the latter case, potential voters' support for party A is $s_2^A = (1 - \alpha) \cdot \theta_t$ and $s_2^B = 1 - (1 - \alpha) \cdot \theta_t$.

The total vote for Party A is $V_t^A = \gamma \cdot (1 - \lambda) + \max\{e_t, E_t\} \cdot \lambda \cdot s_t^A$, and for Party B is $V_t^B = (1 - \gamma) \cdot (1 - \lambda) + \max\{e_t, E_t\} \cdot \lambda \cdot s_t^B$. Party A wins the election with probability $p(V_t^A, V_t^B) = V_t^A / (V_t^A + V_t^B)$. Party B wins with probability $1 - p(V_t^A, V_t^B)$. The winner of the election in period $t = 1$ becomes the incumbent (I_2) for the second period.

3.2 Payoffs and Timing

Each party seeks to maximize the expected discounted probability of holding office. Winning the election yields a flow utility $R > 0$. The future is discounted by $\delta \in (0, 1)$. The total utility for party i is:

$$u_i = \sum_{t=1}^2 \delta^{t-1} \cdot R \cdot \mathbb{I}_{I_{t+1}=i}$$

where the incumbent is determined by the outcome of the election in period t . The timing within period t is as follows.

1. State (I_t, E_t, n_t^A, n_t^B) is known. θ_t is drawn and observed.
2. Incumbent I_t chooses $e_t \in \{0, 1\}$. If $E_t = 1$, $e_t = 1$.
3. Election occurs, and the election winner determines I_{t+1} .

4. State variables $E_{t+1}, n_{t+1}^A, n_{t+1}^B$ update.
5. Payoffs for period t are realized. The game ends if $t = 2$.

4 Equilibrium Characterization

The model admits a unique Perfect Bayesian Nash Equilibrium. In the first period, the incumbent's decision follows a cutpoint strategy based on the observed support of the potential voters. The incumbent enfranchises only when potential voters' intrinsic support, θ_1 , is sufficiently high to outweigh the risks associated with uncertain future preferences. Proposition 1 formalizes this strategy.

Proposition 1. *For any resentment sensitivity α and partisan advantage γ and for any period t , there exists a unique threshold $\theta_t^*(\alpha, \gamma)$ such that Party A enfranchises potential voters in Period t ($e_t = 1$) when $\theta_t \geq \theta_t^*(\alpha, \gamma)$ and maintain exclusion otherwise, and Party B enfranchises potential voters in Period t ($e_t = 1$) when $\theta_t < \theta_t^*$ and maintains exclusion otherwise.*

A central feature of this equilibrium is that an increase in voter resentment sensitivity α has a non-monotonic effect on the incumbent Party A's first-period enfranchisement decision ($e_1 = 1$). This effect is contingent upon Party A's initial partisan advantage among core voters, γ .

Proposition 2. *In the unique equilibrium, there exists a threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha) \in (0, 1)$ such that:*

- (i) *For $\gamma \leq \gamma^*(\alpha)$ (weak partisan base), the probability of first-period enfranchisement is increasing in resentment sensitivity α ;*
- (ii) *For $\gamma > \gamma^*(\alpha)$ (strong partisan base), the probability of first-period enfranchisement is decreasing in α .*

Proof. See Appendix. □

The intuition underlying Proposition 2 rests on two countervailing effects of α on Party A's intertemporal optimization problem. Consider Party A's choice of first-period enfranchisement, $e_1 \in \{0, 1\}$, when it holds office in Period 1. A decision not to enfranchise in Period 1 ($e_1 = 0$) generates resentment toward Party A in Period 2 ($r_2^A = 1$). Then, should potential voters be enfranchised in Period 2 (irrespective of the party in office), higher sensitivity α exacerbates the electoral penalty Party A incurs from resentment. This creates an

incentive for Party A to enfranchise preemptively in Period 1 ($e_1 = 1$) in order to neutralize the future cost of resentment. We refer to this mechanism as the *preemption effect* of resentment sensitivity.

There is also a countervailing dynamic, which we term the *entrenchment effect*. By increasing the electoral penalty associated with enfranchising a resentful group, a higher α makes future enfranchisement less attractive, were the incumbent to face this choice again in Period 2. Consequently, when party A expects to remain in office in Period 2, it recognizes that if it chooses $e_1 = 0$ today it will likely continue to choose $e_t = 0$ in the future, reinforcing incentives to block suffrage today.

The relative strength of Party A's core support, captured by γ , determines which effect dominates. When $\gamma \leq \gamma^*(\alpha)$, Party A cannot confidently rely on its core voters to deliver electoral success in Period 2. In this case, the preemption effect prevails: securing future support from potential voters is critical, and the party seeks to avoid the electoral penalty associated with their resentment. As a result, increases in α strengthen the incentive to enfranchise in Period 1.

Conversely, for a party with a strong partisan base ($\gamma > \gamma^*(\alpha)$), an increase in α reinforces the incentive to disenfranchise. With such a strong base, Party A has a high probability of winning the Period 1 election, irrespective of its enfranchisement choice. Therefore, the party's decision is primarily driven by its optimal strategy in Period 2, when it expects to be the incumbent. Increases in sensitivity α increase the electoral consequences of the initial disenfranchisement ($e_1 = 0$), and enfranchising them in Period 2 would be electorally ineffective due to high resentment. This removes uncertainty about the optimal future path: entrenchment ($e_2 = 0$) becomes the dominant strategy. The ex ante knowledge of this deterministic continuation play makes the initial act of disenfranchisement less costly in expectation, causing the entrenchment effect to outweigh the preemption motive.

Figure 1 depicts the ex ante probability of first-period enfranchisement as a function of resentment sensitivity, α , across varying levels of partisan advantage, γ , and it visually captures the divergent incentives identified in Proposition 2. For sufficiently weak parties (i.e., the green line for all α and the orange and blue lines where $\gamma < \gamma^*(\alpha)$), increases in sensitivity α are associated with increases in the likelihood of enfranchisement; preemption dominates. But for sufficiently strong parties (the orange and blue lines where $\gamma < \gamma^*(\alpha)$), increases in sensitivity are associated with decreases in the likelihood of enfranchisement; entrenchment dominates.

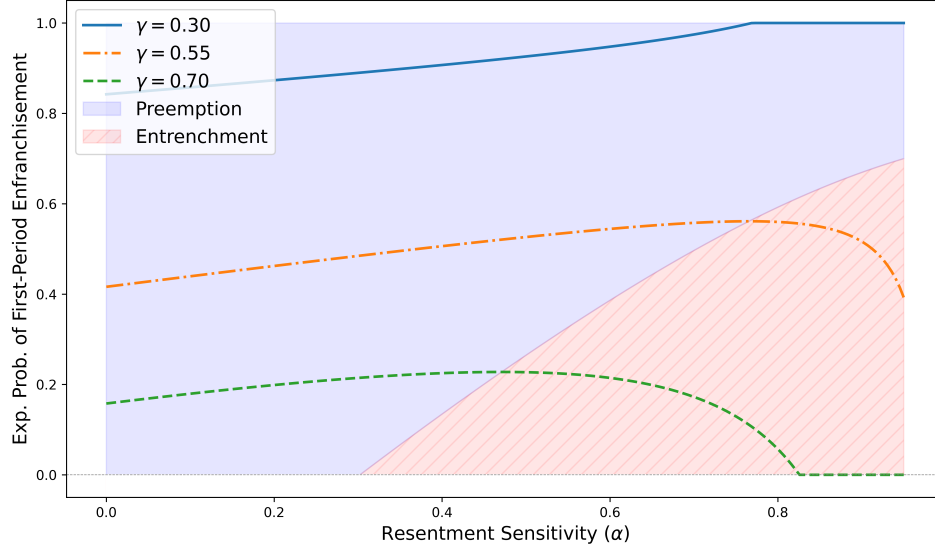


Figure 1: Equilibrium probability of first-period enfranchisement as a function of resentment sensitivity, α . $\delta = 0.9$.

Building on Proposition 2, Proposition 3 characterizes how the critical partisan strength threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ varies with resentment sensitivity α . Recall that $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ characterizes the boundary between the parameter regions where the preemption effect dominates (Party A enfranchises more as α increases) and where the entrenchment effect dominates (Party A enfranchises less as α increases).

Proposition 3. *The partisan advantage threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ is non-increasing in the resentment sensitivity parameter α over the interval $\alpha \in [0, 1]$. That is, $\frac{d\gamma^*(\alpha)}{d\alpha} \leq 0$.*

Proposition 3 establishes that as potential voters become more sensitive to disenfranchisement (higher α), the range of parties for whom the entrenchment effect dominates expands. This result may seem paradoxical, as one might expect a higher penalty for resentment to universally encourage preemption. The intuition lies in how an increase in α disproportionately improves the strategic value of the entrenchment path. A higher α does not merely increase the electoral cost of enfranchising a resentful group; it can render that action so electorally damaging that it is eliminated as a viable option in the Period 2 subgame. This removes strategic ambiguity, cementing partisan entrenchment as the unique optimal continuation play following an initial disenfranchisement.

The downward slope of the threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ is a direct consequence of this dynamic. Figure 2 depicts the threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ at which a party is indifferent between the preemption and entrenchment paths. An increase in α makes the entrenchment path more certain and breaks this indifference, such that a party at the previous threshold now strictly prefers

entrenchment. In essence, as the long-term penalty for historical grievances grows, the political logic of writing off a group of voters entirely becomes strategically coherent for a wider, and weaker, set of political parties.

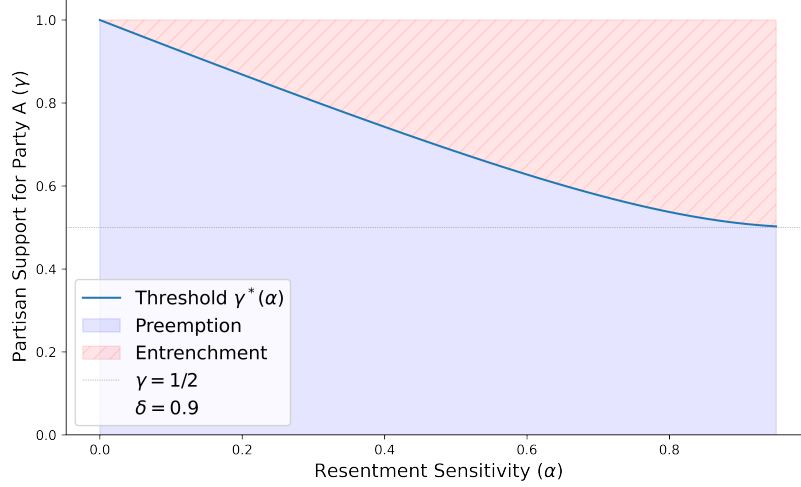


Figure 2: Threshold, γ^* , between the preemption-dominant (blue) and entrenchment-dominant (red) strategies as a function of resentment sensitivity, α . $\delta = 0.9$.

5 Uncertainty

The preceding analysis characterized the equilibrium under the assumption that parties possess perfect information about the latent partisan alignment, θ_t , of potential voters. While this allows us to isolate the core strategic incentives, political actors in reality operate under significant uncertainty, forming beliefs on potential voters' partisanship from imperfect signals. Such signals may take the form of polling data, group heuristics, or visible political actions like marches. To explore the implications of such informational frictions, we now relax the perfect information assumption.

Specifically, assume that parties do not observe θ_t directly and instead share a common public signal η_t , which can be interpreted as the number of supporters for Party A in a survey of N potential voters. This signal is drawn from a binomial distribution $\eta_t \sim \text{Binomial}(N, \theta_t)$. Given a uniform prior for θ_t , the shared posterior belief after observing η_t is given by a Beta distribution

$$\theta_t | \eta_t \sim \text{Beta}(\eta_t + 1, N - \eta_t + 1). \quad (1)$$

This framework nests the complete-information model as a limit case: as the signal's precision increases (as N approaches infinity), the sample mean $\hat{\theta}_t := \eta_t/N$ converges to the true value

θ_t .

We now show that the core strategic trade-off from our baseline model is robust to this informational friction, although its nature is now mediated by the quality of information.

Proposition 4. *In the unique equilibrium with imperfect information, there exists a threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha, N) \in (0, 1)$, such that:*

- (i) *For $\gamma \leq \gamma^*(\alpha, N)$ (weak partisan advantage), the probability of first-period enfranchisement is increasing in resentment sensitivity α ;*
- (ii) *For $\gamma > \gamma^*(\alpha, N)$ (strong partisan advantage), the probability of first-period enfranchisement is decreasing in resentment sensitivity α .*

Proof. See Appendix. □

Proposition 4 establishes that the qualitative structure of the equilibrium is robust to the introduction of informational frictions. The choice between preempting future resentment and committing to a path of partisan entrenchment persists under uncertainty. The non-monotonic relationship between enfranchisement probability and resentment sensitivity (α) also remains, as illustrated in Figure 3⁶. The key difference is that the threshold, $\gamma^{**}(\alpha, N)$, now endogenously depends on the quality of information available to the parties.

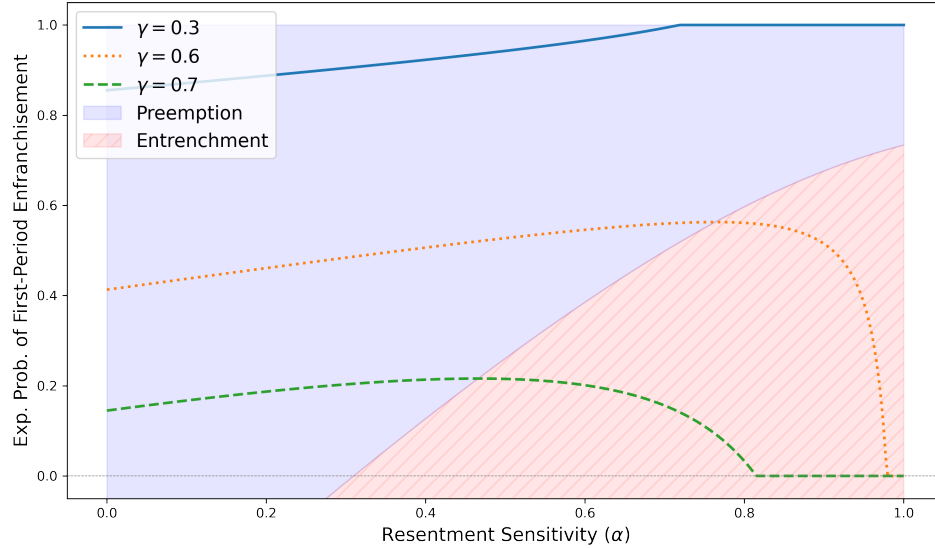


Figure 3: Expected probability of the first-period enfranchisement as a function of the resentment sensitivity, α . $\delta = 0.9$, $N = 50$.

⁶Figure 3 shows the probability of enfranchisement versus α for different values of γ , analogous to Figure ?? but for the model with uncertainty.

Proposition 5. *There exists a threshold $\gamma^{**}(\alpha, N) \in (0, 1)$ such that the probability Party A enfranchises in Period 1*

1. *decreases in signal precision N if $\gamma < \gamma^{**}(\alpha, N)$;*
2. *increases in signal precision N if $\gamma > \gamma^{**}(\alpha, N)$.*

Signal precision (N) affects the incumbent's (Party A's) Period 1 enfranchisement decision through two opposing channels. First, there is an *immediate information effect*. Higher signal precision makes the current signal η_1 a more reliable estimate of the potential voters' true alignment, θ_1 . It diminishes the risk of enfranchising a group that is unexpectedly hostile and of failing to enfranchise a supportive one. By making the outcome of enfranchisement less uncertain, higher precision increases the expected value of acting on a favorable signal, thereby creating an incentive for immediate enfranchisement (lowering the threshold θ_1^*). Second, there is a *continuation information effect*. Higher precision means that the signal in Period 2, η_2 , will also become more accurate. This increases the expected utility of the entire continuation game that follows the choice $e_1 = 0$. Consequently, the strategic path of delaying the decision becomes more attractive, creating an incentive to forgo enfranchisement in Period 1.

Again, the net effect depends on the Incumbent's baseline partisan advantage, γ . When partisan advantage is sufficiently high ($\gamma > \gamma^{**}$), Party A expects to retain office in Period 2 regardless of whether it enfranchises in Period 1. In this region, the continuation game following $e_1 = 0$ is mostly characterized by entrenchment: because non-enfranchisement in Period 1 generates resentment, Period 2 enfranchisement – if revisited – becomes electorally unattractive except under extremely favorable realizations. As a result, additional precision about the Period 2 electorate has limited strategic value. What precision does change is the attractiveness of enfranchising *now*: a higher N makes η_1 a more reliable indicator of θ_1 , reducing the risk that early enfranchisement inadvertently mobilizes a hostile group. The immediate information effect dominates, and higher precision increases the likelihood of enfranchisement.

In contrast, when party A's partisan advantage is low ($\gamma < \gamma^*(\alpha)$), the continuation information effect dominates. Because enfranchisement is absorbing, choosing $e_1 = 1$ commits the incumbent to facing the potential-voter bloc in both periods. For a weak party, the central danger is an irreversible false positive: enfranchising on a noisy favorable signal and granting suffrage to a hostile group, which can cost office in Period 1. By choosing $e_1 = 0$, the incumbent preserves discretion for Period 2 – conditional on winning the election. Higher precision N reduces the likelihood of mistakenly enfranchising in Period 2 when resentment would make inclusion especially costly. Hence, for weak incumbents, improved information

increases the expected value of waiting more than the expected value of acting immediately, so the continuation information effect dominates and first-period enfranchisement becomes less likely as N rises.

Figure 4 illustrates Proposition 4. When γ is low, increases in N reduce likelihood of enfranchisement. When γ is high, the relationship reverses.

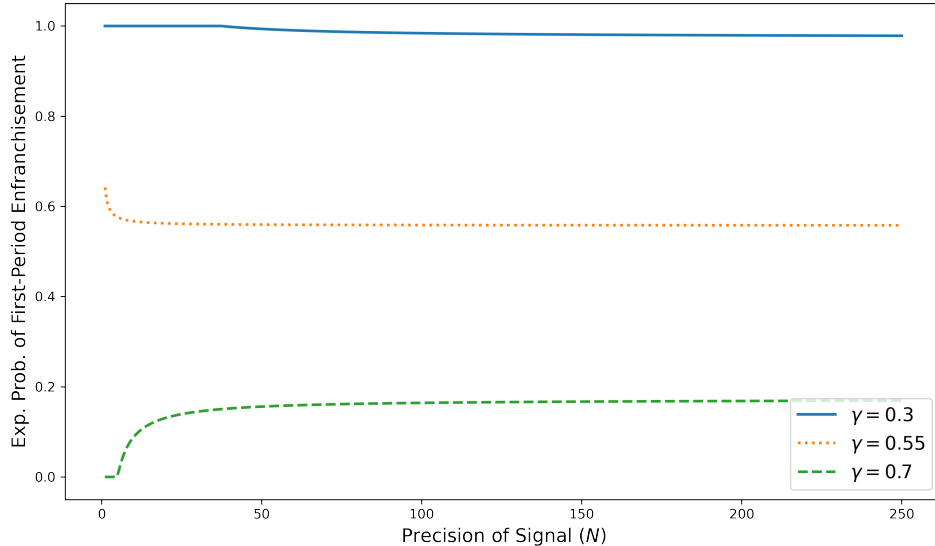


Figure 4: Expected probability of the first-period enfranchisement as a function of the information precision, N . $\alpha = 0.7$, $\delta = 0.9$.

6 Discussion

We contend that newly enfranchised voters care about parties' positions on their enfranchisement. In this paper, we argue that voter resentment toward parties' past enfranchisement decisions is a crucial, endogenous feature of the politics of enfranchisement. We develop a formal model showing that a party's decision to extend suffrage depends fundamentally on the dynamic tension between two forces: the incentive to preempt future electoral punishment (in the form of voter resentment) and the incentive to entrench its power by relying on a loyal base.

Our central theoretical contribution is that a party's existing partisan strength determines which of these incentives dominates. For electorally vulnerable parties, the threat of creating a resentful voting bloc encourages enfranchisement. For dominant parties, the same threat can rationalize a strategy of permanent exclusion. We next apply these results to debates surrounding the Voting Rights Act of 1965 and then consider the implications of the results for pro-democracy activists who seek to expand the franchise. Both applications illustrate

that partisan competition is a critical precondition for the expansion of democratic rights.

6.1 Historical applications

The model’s logic offers a new perspective on the political calculations of Southern Democrats during the U.S. Civil Rights era. For decades, the Democratic party in the South maintained a one-party state built on the mass disenfranchisement of Black Americans. In the context of our model, these political actors represent incumbents with exceptionally high partisan advantage (γ). The Civil Rights Movement of the 1950s and 1960s, with marches, voter registration drives, and litigation, dramatically raised the salience of this exclusion. This corresponds to a sharp increase in the resentment sensitivity (α) of the disenfranchised group.

Our model predicts that for an actor with such a high γ , an increase in α makes enfranchisement less likely. This provides a theoretical basis for the stalwart opposition adopted by many Southern Democrats. Faced with a disenfranchised group that was now highly activated and justifiably resentful, these politicians calculated that the electoral costs of enfranchisement outweighed any potential benefits. The model implies that their strategy was not simply an ideological reaction, but a coherent, if ultimately doomed, electoral choice. Rather than attempting to appeal to a new and hostile electorate, they chose to entrench their position by doubling down on their existing base of White voters.

The results, in addition to accounting for Southerners’ massive resistance, also suggest why some Southern Democrats were more receptive to voting rights. There is correlational evidence that Southern Democrats from districts with growing Republican support were more open to Black voting rights. The Republican party, which was dormant for decades, began its resurgence primarily by organizing in and near urban centers in the 1950s (Brunn and Ingalls, 1972). Our model predicts that politicians facing such political competition would be more likely to support enfranchisement. Qualitative patterns are consistent with this prediction: White support for Black voting rights often came from urban centers (Werner, 2009), which were also home to an emerging Republican party. Future research should more precisely measure Republican party strength and politicians’ support for the VRA in order to test this hypothesis.

6.2 Pro-democracy movements

The theory’s implications extend beyond historical cases; indeed, the theory suggests a paradoxical challenge for modern voting rights movements. We contend that activism that highlights the injustice of disenfranchisement or the importance of voting rights corresponds

to an increase in non-voters' resentment sensitivity (α). Our model would suggest that such activism, as seen in ongoing efforts to enfranchise former felons and non-citizen residents, can successfully pressure incumbents in competitive environments to extend the franchise. However, that same activism may cause dominant parties to become even more resistant to reform. Not only might these movements backfire against strong incumbents, but they can also move a middling party from preemption to entrenchment. Our model captures this dynamic in the downward-sloping threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha)$: as disenfranchisement becomes more salient, the set of parties for which it is strategically optimal to entrench expands.

The implications of activism are conditional on the level of partisan competition. Activism that raises the salience of the franchise is most effective where competition is already tight and incumbent cannot afford to forgo support from newly enfranchised voters. Where one party is dominant, however, heightened resentment can instead postpone inclusion. In such cases, suffrage advocates may need to pair rights-based mobilization with efforts that increase electoral competitiveness, like coalition-building, registering existing constituents, and supporting viable challengers, so that enfranchisement becomes strategically attractive for the incumbent.

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7 Appendix

7.1 Analysis of the Baseline Model

We solve the game by backward induction.

Period 2 (Terminal Period)

At the start of period 2, the state is $(I_2, \theta_2, E_2, n_2^A, n_2^B)$. Resentment (r_2^A, r_2^B) is determined by the outcome of period 1.

Case 1: Enfranchisement already happened ($E_2 = 1$) If $E_2 = 1$, potential voters were enfranchised in period 1 ($e_1 = 1$). This implies $n_2^A = n_2^B = 0$, so $r_2^A = 0$ and $r_2^B = 0$. Potential voters participate in the election. The vote shares of potential voters are $s_2^A = (1 - \alpha)\theta_2 + \alpha(\theta_2(1 - 0) + (1 - \theta_1)0) = \theta_2$ and $s_2^B = (1 - \alpha)(1 - \theta_2) + \alpha(\theta_2(0) + (1 - \theta_2)(1 - 0)) = 1 - \theta_2$. Total votes are $V_2^A = (1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot \theta_2$ and $V_2^B = (1 - \lambda) \cdot (1 - \gamma) + \lambda \cdot (1 - \theta_2)$. Party A

wins the election with probability:

$$\begin{aligned} p(V_2^A, V_2^B) &= \frac{(1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \theta_2}{(1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \theta_2 + (1-\lambda) \cdot (1-\gamma) + \lambda(1-\theta_2)} \\ &= \frac{(1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \theta_2}{1-\lambda+\lambda} = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \theta_2 \end{aligned}$$

The expected win probability for any incumbent i in period 1 when $E_2 = 1$ is the expected value of $p(V_2^i, V_2^{-i})$ over $\theta_2 \sim U[0, 1]$. For $I_2 = A$, this is $\int_0^1 ((1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \theta_2) d\theta_2 = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \frac{\lambda}{2}$.

Case 2: Enfranchisement has not happened yet ($E_2 = 0$) If $E_2 = 0$, potential voters were not enfranchised in period 1 ($e_1 = 0$). Since $I_1 = A$, this implies $n_2^A = 1$ and $n_2^B = 0$. The resentment levels are $r_2^A = 1, r_2^B = 0$. The incumbent I_2 (winner of the period 1 election) must decide $e_2 \in \{0, 1\}$.

If A wins election in the first period ($I_2 = A$): The state is $(I_2 = A, \theta_2, E_2 = 0, r_A = 1, r_B = 0)$. A chooses $e_2 \in \{0, 1\}$. If $e_2 = 1$: potential voters participate. Vote shares of potential voters are $s_2^A = (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2 + \alpha \cdot (\theta_2 \cdot (1-1) + (1-\theta_2) \cdot 0) = (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2$. $s_2^B = 1 - s_2^A = 1 - (1-\alpha)\theta_2$. Total votes: $V_2^A = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2$, $V_2^B = (1-\lambda) \cdot (1-\gamma) + \lambda \cdot (1 - (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2)$. A wins with probability $(1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2$.

If $e_2 = 0$: potential voters do not participate. Total votes: $V_2^A = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma$, $V_2^B = (1-\lambda) \cdot (1-\gamma)$. A wins with probability γ .

A observes θ_2 and chooses $e_2 = 1$ if its win probability is higher with $e_2 = 1$ than with $e_2 = 0$. Recall that $\lambda > 0$ and $1-\alpha > 0$.

$$\begin{aligned} (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2 &> \gamma \\ \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2 &> \lambda \cdot \gamma \end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

So, Party A chooses $e_2 = 1$ when $\theta_2 > \frac{\gamma}{1-\alpha}$. Otherwise, it chooses $e_2 = 0$.

Let $\theta_2^* := \frac{\gamma}{1-\alpha}$. θ^* determines the threshold above which A enfranchises potential voters in the second period.

If B wins election in the first period ($I_2 = B$): The state is $(I_2 = B, \theta_2, E_2 = 0, r_A = 1, r_B = 0)$ (as $I_1 = A$ chose $e_1 = 0$). B chooses $e_2 \in \{0, 1\}$. If $e_2 = 1$: potential voters participate. Vote shares of potential voters are $s_2^A = (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2 + \alpha \cdot (\theta_2 \cdot (1-1) + (1-\theta_2) \cdot 0) = (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2$ and $s_2^B = (1-\alpha) \cdot (1-\theta_2) + \alpha \cdot (\theta_2 \cdot (1) + (1-\theta_2) \cdot (1-0)) = (1-\alpha)(1-\theta_2) + \alpha$. Total votes are $V_2^A = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2$ and $V_2^B = (1-\lambda) \cdot (1-\gamma) + \lambda \cdot ((1-\alpha) \cdot (1-\theta_2) + \alpha)$. B wins with probability $(1-\lambda)(1-\gamma) + \lambda(1-\alpha)(1-\theta_2) + \lambda \cdot \alpha$.

If $e_2 = 0$: potential voters do not participate. Total votes: $V_2^A = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma$, $V_2^B = (1-\lambda)(1-\gamma)$. B wins with probability $1-\gamma$. B chooses $e_2 = 1$ if its win probability is

higher with $e_2 = 1$ than with $e_2 = 0$:

$$(1 - \lambda) \cdot (1 - \gamma) + \lambda \cdot (1 - \theta_2) + \lambda \cdot \alpha \cdot \theta_2 > 1 - \gamma$$

$$-\lambda \cdot (1 - \gamma) + \lambda \cdot (1 - \theta_2) + \lambda \cdot \alpha \cdot \theta_2 > 0$$

$$\gamma - \theta_2 \cdot (1 - \alpha) > 0$$

Given $\lambda > 0$, $1 - \alpha > 0$, Party B chooses $e_2 = 1$ when $\theta_2 < \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha} = \theta_2^*$. Otherwise, it chooses $e_2 = 0$.

The expected period 2 win probability for A We can now compute the ex-ante expected win probabilities for A in the second period.

Given $I_2 = A$, $E_2 = 0$, $r_A = 1$, and $r_B = 0$:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{I}_{\text{A wins in } t=2} | I_2 = A, E_2 = 0] &= \\ &Pr[\theta_2 < \theta_2^*] \cdot \gamma + Pr[\theta_2 \geq \theta_2^*] \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot \mathbb{E}[\theta_2 | \theta_2 \geq \theta_2^*]) = \\ &\theta_2^* \cdot \gamma + (1 - \theta_2^*) \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot \frac{1 + \theta_2^*}{2}) \\ &= \gamma \cdot (1 - \lambda) + \frac{\lambda}{2} \cdot \frac{(1 - \alpha)^2 + \gamma^2}{1 - \alpha} \end{aligned} \quad (3)$$

Given $I_2 = B$ and $E_2 = 0$, $r_A = 1$, $r_B = 0$:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{I}_{\text{A wins in } t=2} | I_2 = B, E_2 = 0] &= \\ &Pr[\theta_2 \geq \theta_2^*] \cdot \gamma + Pr[\theta_2 < \theta_2^*] \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot \mathbb{E}[\theta_2 | \theta_2 < \theta_2^*]) \\ &= (1 - \theta_2^*) \cdot \gamma + \theta_2^* \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot \frac{\theta_2^*}{2}) \\ &= \frac{\gamma \cdot ((1 - \alpha) - \gamma \cdot \frac{\lambda}{2})}{1 - \alpha} \end{aligned} \quad (4)$$

Period 1

Party A is the incumbent in the first period ($I_1 = A$). The state is ($I_1 = A, \theta_1, E_1 = 0, n_1^A = 0, n_1^B = 0$). Resentment is $r_1^A = r_1^B = 0$. Party A chooses e_1 to maximize expected total utility $U_A(e_1) = R \cdot \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{I}_{\text{A wins in } t=1}] + \delta \cdot R \cdot \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{I}_{\text{A wins in } t=2}]$.

If $e_1 = 1$,

$$U_A(e_1 = 1) = R \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot \theta_1) + R \cdot \delta \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot 1/2). \quad (5)$$

If $e_1 = 0$,

$$\begin{aligned} U_A(e_1 = 0) &= Pr[\mathbb{I}_A \text{ wins in } t=1] \cdot (R + \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{I}_A \text{ wins in } t=2 | I_2 = A]) + Pr[\mathbb{I}_A \text{ loses in } t=1] \cdot (0 + \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{I}_A \text{ wins in } t=2 | I_2 = B]) \\ &= \gamma \cdot (R + R \cdot \delta \cdot (\gamma \cdot (1 - \lambda) + \frac{\lambda}{2} \cdot \frac{(1 - \alpha)^2 + \gamma^2}{1 - \alpha})) + (1 - \gamma) \cdot (0 + R \cdot \delta \cdot \gamma \cdot \frac{(1 - \alpha) - \gamma \cdot \lambda/2}{1 - \alpha}) \end{aligned} \quad (6)$$

Party A chooses $e_1 = 1$ if $U_A(e_1 = 1) > U_A(e_1 = 0)$. Party A chooses $e_1 = 1$ when

$$\theta_1 > \theta_1^*(\alpha, \gamma) := \frac{2 \cdot \gamma \cdot (1 - \alpha) + \delta \cdot (3 \cdot \gamma \cdot (1 - \gamma) + 2 \cdot \gamma^2 \cdot (\alpha + \gamma) - \alpha \cdot \gamma \cdot (4 - \alpha) - (1 - \alpha))}{2 \cdot (1 - \alpha)} \quad (7)$$

and chooses $e_0 = 0$ otherwise.

Note that the threshold θ_1^* decreases in α when

$$\frac{\partial \theta_1^*}{\partial \alpha} = \frac{-\delta \cdot \gamma \cdot ((1 - \alpha)^2 + \gamma \cdot (1 - 2 \cdot \gamma))}{2 \cdot (1 - \alpha)^2} < 0. \quad (8)$$

Thus, θ_1^* decreases in α when $\gamma \leq \gamma^*(\alpha) := \frac{1 + \sqrt{9 - 16\alpha + 8\alpha^2}}{4}$ and increases in α otherwise.

7.2 Analysis of the Model with Uncertainty

We solve the game by backward induction.

Period 2 (Terminal Period)

At the start of period 2, the state is $(I_2, \theta_2, E_2, n_2^A, n_2^B)$. Resentment (r_2^A, r_2^B) is determined by the outcome of period 1.

Case 1: Enfranchisement already happened ($E_2 = 1$) If $E_2 = 1$, potential voters were enfranchised in period 1 ($e_1 = 1$). This implies $n_2^A = n_2^B = 0$, so $r_2^A = 0$ and $r_2^B = 0$. The vote shares are $s_2^A = (1 - \alpha) \cdot \theta_2 + \alpha \cdot (\theta_2 \cdot (1 - 0) + (1 - \theta_2) \cdot 0) = \theta_2$ and $s_2^B = 1 - \theta_2$. Total votes are $V_2^A = (1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot \theta_2$ and $V_2^B = (1 - \lambda) \cdot (1 - \gamma) + \lambda \cdot (1 - \theta_2)$. Party A wins the election with probability $(1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot \theta_2$.

Case 2: Enfranchisement has not happened yet ($E_2 = 0$) If $E_2 = 0$, potential voters were not enfranchised in period 1 ($e_1 = 0$). Since $I_1 = A$, this implies $n_2^A = 1$ and $n_2^B = 0$. The resentment levels are $r_2^A = 1, r_2^B = 0$. The incumbent I_2 (winner of the period 1 election) must decide $e_2 \in \{0, 1\}$.

If A is incumbent ($I_2 = A$): A observes η_2 and chooses $e_2 \in \{0, 1\}$. If $e_2 = 1$: potential voters participate in the election. Vote shares are $s_2^A = (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2 + \alpha \cdot (\theta_2 \cdot (1-1) + (1-\theta_2) \cdot 0) = (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2$. $s_2^B = 1 - (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2$. Total votes: $V_2^A = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2$, $V_2^B = (1-\lambda) \cdot (1-\gamma) + \lambda \cdot (1 - (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2)$. Party A expected probability to win the election

$$\mathbb{E}[(1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2 | \eta_2] = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \frac{1+\eta_2}{2+N}. \quad (9)$$

If $e_2 = 0$: potential voters do not participate in the election. Total votes: $V_2^A = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma$, $V_2^B = (1-\lambda) \cdot (1-\gamma)$. A wins with probability γ . A chooses $e_2 = 1$ if its win probability is higher with $e_2 = 1$ than with $e_2 = 0$:

$$(1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda(1-\alpha) \cdot \frac{1+\eta_2}{2+N} > \gamma$$

$$\eta_2 > \eta_2^* := \frac{(2+N) \cdot \gamma}{(1-\alpha)} - 1 \quad (10)$$

So, Party A chooses $e_2 = 1$ when $\eta_2 > \eta_2^*$. Otherwise, it chooses $e_2 = 0$.

If B is incumbent ($I_2 = B$): The state is $(B, \theta_2, E_2 = 0, r_A = 1, r_B = 0)$ (as $I_1 = A$ chose $e_1 = 0$). B chooses $e_2 \in \{0, 1\}$. If $e_2 = 1$: potential voters participate in the election. Vote shares are $s_2^A = (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2 + \alpha \cdot (\theta_2 \cdot (1-1) + (1-\theta_2) \cdot 0) = (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2$, $s_2^B = (1-\alpha)(1-\theta_2) + \alpha$. Total votes: $V_2^A = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2$, $V_2^B = (1-\lambda) \cdot (1-\gamma) + \lambda \cdot ((1-\alpha)(1-\theta_2) + \alpha)$. Party B expects to win with probability

$$\mathbb{E}[(1-\lambda) \cdot (1-\gamma) + \lambda \cdot (1-\theta_2 \cdot (1-\alpha)) | \eta_2] = (1-\lambda) \cdot (1-\gamma) + \lambda \cdot (1 - \frac{1+\eta_2}{2+N} \cdot (1-\alpha)) \quad (11)$$

If $e_2 = 0$: potential voters do not participate. Total votes: $V_2^A = (1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma$, $V_2^B = (1-\lambda) \cdot (1-\gamma)$. B wins with probability $1-\gamma$. B chooses $e_2 = 1$ if its win probability is higher with $e_2 = 1$ than with $e_2 = 0$, thus Party B chooses $e_2 = 1$ when $\eta_2 \leq \eta_2^*$ and does not enfranchise otherwise.

The expected period 2 win probability for A

Expected win probability for A given $I_2 = A$ and $E_2 = 0, r_A = 1, r_B = 0$:

$$\begin{aligned} & \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{I}_{\text{A wins in } t=2} | I_2 = A, E_2 = 0] \\ &= Pr[\eta_2 \leq \eta_2^*] \cdot \gamma + Pr[\eta_2 > \eta_2^*] \cdot \mathbb{E}[(1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \theta_2 | \eta_2 > \eta_2^*] \\ &= \frac{\eta_2^* + 1}{N+1} \cdot \gamma + \frac{N - \eta_2^*}{N+1} \cdot ((1-\lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1-\alpha) \cdot \frac{N + \eta_2^* + 3}{2 \cdot (N+2)}). \end{aligned} \quad (12)$$

Expected win probability for A given $I_2 = B$ and $E_2 = 0, r_A = 1, r_B = 0$:

$$\begin{aligned}
& \mathbb{E}[\mathbb{I}_{\text{A wins in } t=2} | I_2 = B, E_2 = 0] \\
&= Pr[\eta_2 > \eta_2^*] \cdot \gamma + Pr[\eta_2 \leq \eta_2^*] \cdot \mathbb{E}[(1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot \theta_2 | \eta_2 \leq \eta_2^*] \\
&= \frac{N - \eta_2^*}{N + 1} \cdot \gamma + \frac{\eta_2^* + 1}{N + 1} \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot \frac{\eta_2^* + 2}{2 \cdot (N + 2)}).
\end{aligned} \tag{13}$$

Period 1

Party A is the incumbent ($I_1 = A$). If $e_1 = 1$ potential voters participate. Party A's expected utility is

$$\begin{aligned}
& \mathbb{E}[U_A(e_1 = 1) | I_1 = A] \\
&= R \cdot \mathbb{E}[(1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot \theta_1 | \eta_1] + R \cdot \delta \cdot \mathbb{E}[(1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot \theta_2] \\
&= R \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot \frac{1 + \eta_1}{2 + N}) + R \cdot \delta \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda/2)
\end{aligned} \tag{14}$$

When $e_1 = 0$, Party A's expected utility is

$$\begin{aligned}
& \mathbb{E}[U_A(e_1 = 0) | I_1 = A] \\
&= \gamma \cdot \left(R + R \cdot \delta \cdot \left(\frac{\eta_2^* + 1}{N + 1} \cdot \gamma + \frac{N - \eta_2^*}{N + 1} \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot \frac{N + \eta_2^* + 3}{2 \cdot (N + 2)}) \right) \right) \\
&\quad + (1 - \gamma) \cdot \left(0 + R \cdot \delta \cdot \left(\frac{N - \eta_2^*}{N + 1} \cdot \gamma + \frac{\eta_2^* + 1}{N + 1} \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot \frac{\eta_2^* + 2}{2 \cdot (N + 2)}) \right) \right)
\end{aligned} \tag{15}$$

Party A chooses $e_1 = 1$ if $U_A(e_1 = 1 | \theta_1) > U_A(e_1 = 0)$. There exists a threshold η_1^* such that Party A chooses $e_1 = 1$ when $\eta_1 > \eta_1^*$ and chooses $e_1 = 0$ otherwise. This threshold is

$$\eta_1^* := \left(\frac{\mathbb{E}[U_A(e_1 = 0) | I_1 = A] - R \cdot \delta \cdot ((1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma + \lambda/2)}{R} - (1 - \lambda) \cdot \gamma \right) \cdot \frac{2 + N}{\lambda} - 1 \tag{16}$$

Denote $\hat{\theta}_1^* : \eta_1^*/N$. It reflects sample mean threshold such that potential voters are enfranchised when observed sample mean exceeds $\hat{\theta}_1^*$. We next analyze how $\hat{\theta}_1^*$ changes with α .

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{\partial \hat{\theta}_1^*}{\partial \alpha} &= \frac{-\delta \cdot \gamma \cdot ((1 + N) \cdot (1 - \alpha)^2 + (2 + n) \cdot \gamma \cdot (1 - 2 \cdot \gamma))}{2 \cdot (1 - \alpha)^2} \cdot \frac{2 + N}{N \cdot (1 + N)} \\
&= \frac{-\delta \cdot \gamma \cdot ((1 - \alpha)^2 + \gamma \cdot (1 - 2 \cdot \gamma))}{2 \cdot (1 - \alpha)^2} \cdot \frac{2 + N}{1 + N} \\
&\quad + \frac{-\delta \cdot \gamma \cdot ((1 - \alpha)^2 + 2 \cdot \gamma \cdot (1 - 2 \cdot \gamma))}{2 \cdot (1 - \alpha)^2} \cdot \frac{2 + N}{N \cdot (1 + N)}.
\end{aligned} \tag{17}$$

The threshold $\hat{\theta}_1^*$ decreases in α when $\gamma \leq \gamma^*(\alpha, N) := \frac{1 + \sqrt{\frac{9-16\cdot\alpha+8\cdot\alpha^2}{2/N+1} + \frac{10-16\cdot\alpha+8\cdot\alpha^2}{2+N}}}{4}$ and increases in α otherwise. Additionally, the threshold $\gamma^*(\alpha, N)$ decreases in α (equation 18) and increases in N (equation 19).

$$\frac{\partial \gamma^*(\alpha, N)}{\partial \alpha} = -\frac{2 \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot (1 + N)}{\sqrt{2 + N} \cdot \sqrt{10 + 9 \cdot N - 16 \cdot \alpha \cdot (1 + N) + 8 \cdot \alpha^2 \cdot (1 + N)}} < 0, \quad (18)$$

$$\frac{\partial \gamma^*(\alpha, N)}{\partial N} = -\frac{(1 - \alpha)^2 \cdot \sqrt{2 + N}}{(2 + N)^2 \cdot \sqrt{10 + 9 \cdot N - 16 \cdot \alpha \cdot (1 + N) + 8 \cdot \alpha^2 \cdot (1 + N)}} > 0, \quad (19)$$

Finally, we analyze how $\hat{\theta}_1^*$ changes with signal precision N .

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial \hat{\theta}_1^*}{\partial N} &= \frac{(1 - \alpha) \cdot (1 - 2 \cdot \gamma + \delta) - \delta \cdot \gamma \cdot (2 + \alpha^2) \cdot (1 + N)^2}{2 \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot N^2 \cdot (1 + N)^2} \\ &+ \frac{\delta \cdot \gamma \cdot (\alpha \cdot (10 + 20 \cdot N + 9 \cdot N^2) - (1 + \gamma \cdot (2 \cdot (\alpha - \gamma) - 3)) \cdot (4 + 8 \cdot N + 3 \cdot N^2))}{2 \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot N^2 \cdot (1 + N)^2} \end{aligned} \quad (20)$$

The sign of $\frac{\partial \hat{\theta}_1^*}{\partial N}$ is equal to the sign of the numerator denote the numerator as A . Note that

$$\lim_{\gamma \rightarrow 0} A = 4 \cdot (1 - \alpha) \cdot (1 + N)^2 > 0;$$

$$\lim_{\gamma \rightarrow 1} A = -4 \cdot (1 + N)^2 - 2 \cdot \alpha^2 \cdot (1 + N)^2 + \alpha \cdot (2 + 4 \cdot N + 3 \cdot N^2),$$

both roots of the latter are outside $[0, 1]$ interval, therefore $\lim_{\gamma \rightarrow 1} A < 0$. It implies that there always exists a partition of γ space such that $\hat{\theta}_1^*$ decreases in N for some parts of this partition and increases in N otherwise. We now show that there exists a *unique* threshold $\gamma^{**}(\alpha, N)$ such that $\hat{\theta}_1^*$ increases in signal precision when γ is lower than this threshold and decreases in precision otherwise.

Note that A is a third-degree polynomial.

$$\lim_{\alpha \rightarrow 1} A = \gamma^2 \cdot (1 - 2 \cdot \gamma) \cdot (4 + 8 \cdot N + 3 \cdot N^2),$$

which has three roots: $\gamma_1, \gamma_2 = 0$ and $\gamma_3 = 1/2$. Next note that

$$\begin{aligned}
\lim_{\gamma \rightarrow 0} \frac{\partial A}{\partial \alpha} &= \lim_{\gamma \rightarrow 0} -4 \cdot (1 + N)^2 + \gamma \cdot (14 - 4 \cdot \alpha + (28 - 8 \cdot \alpha) \cdot N + (13 - 4 \cdot \alpha) \cdot N^2) \\
&\quad - 2 \cdot \gamma^2 \cdot (4 + 8 \cdot N + 3 \cdot N^2) \\
&= -4 \cdot (1 + N)^2 < 0,
\end{aligned}$$

which implies that there exists a unique root $\gamma^{**}(\alpha, N)$.